

sive feature of the lot. Other nifty features, such as wall mounting, support for DVD player connectivity via RCA or S-video inputs and colour calibrating software, are also available.

The Samsung 171S is built around a different strategy—it is made for the value-conscious buyers. This LCD features an all carbon black body with the buttons placed at the upper right hand corner of the 17-inch screen. One interesting feature is the ability of the monitor to be used in landscape or portrait mode—this can be achieved by using the provided software. The monitor also has other nifty features, such as height adjustment, wall mounting, etc. Unfortunately, it lacks DVI support and in-built speakers. The accessories provided along with the monitor include a user guide, colour calibrating software, driver CD and the pivot configuring software.

The Philips 170 B4MG was another feature-packed LCD in the 17-inch category. This monitor comes with the option of portrait or landscape mode, which is a niche feature considering that only two LCD monitors in our test had it. It also has an optional USB hub feature, in-built speakers, height adjustment and a screen tilt angle of 175 degrees. The package included the monitor, manuals, and the driver CD. The user manual was pretty exhaustive, but there was no colour software included.

The LG Flatron 1710B had three USB ports, and a tilt angle of 140 degrees. The ViewSonic VG700 LCD was also gunning for the glory with a decent design. The VG700 comes with integrated speakers and a Kensington lock as an optional accessory, so that you can secure it to your desktop. It also comes with its own colour calibrating software.

All other 17-inch LCDs in our test either had too few features to mention or they came with the standard features that did not justify their high price tag.

Test Analysis

LCDs were put through three additional tests, namely OSD usability, a viewable angle test in which a document containing different fonts was opened and read at various angles, and the LCD Pixel Persistence test to check for blurring, ghosting or streaking.

The CMV1512 topped these in the 15-inch category, as it was the only monitor in which we could read the document clearly from an angle of 160 degrees—perfect for presentations. The OSD is also very convenient and easy to operate.

It performed above average in the pixel persistence test.

The Sharp LL-T15G3 stood second, because despite a good score in the Pixel Persistence and Viewable Angle tests, it performed poorly in the OSD test.

There were five models vying for the third position. The HCL HCM 700LSA, the HCL HCM 500SLA and the CMV1515 TFT's performances were below average in the Pixel Persistence and Viewable Angle tests—the document could not be read, and a distinct blue and yellow tinge was seen. This makes these LCDs a bad choice for watching movies or playing games.

Moving on to the 17-inches category, Samsung Syncmaster 171s stood first because of its good performance in the Pixel Persistence and OSD Usability test. Its performance in the Viewable Angle test was also above average.

The LG Flatron 1710B stood second by performing extremely well in this test. It lost out because of its poor performance in the LCD Pixel Persistence test, when a certain amount of blurring was noticeable.

On the other hand, the Acer AL 712's performance in this test was mediocre, especially in the Viewable Angle and Pixel Persistence tests—the document could be read at a maximum angle of 140 degrees.

Glossary

Aperture Pitch: The equivalent of horizontal dot pitch on shadow mask CRTs; the distance between one stripe and the next one of the same colour, expressed in millimetres; also known as Stripe Pitch.

Auto sizing: The ability of a monitor to maintain a consistent image size across different video modes.

Anti-reflective coating: A special coating, applied to the front of the CRT, to reduce glare. Anti-reflective coatings enrich the colour black by decreasing the amount of light reflected off the front of the screen by outside sources. This helps black text stand out on white backgrounds, aiding in readability.

Bandwidth: Expressed in megahertz, bandwidth is a measurement of a monitor's pixel clock. The higher the pixel clock, the higher the Bandwidth requirement of the Video Amplifier.

Bezel: This is the outer frame of the front face of a computer monitor that holds the CRT inside the monitor cabinet.

BNC Connector: A connector for coaxial cable designed to lock two ends together when one end is inserted into the other and turned 90 degrees. BNC connectors do not support the Windows Plug and Play Standards.

Colour Calibration: The necessary adjustment of colours that causes the colours on the monitor to match the ones produced by the printer. Without adequate calibration, the printed page may not accurately reproduce what is displayed on the computer screen.

Colour Depth: Colour depth is determined by the number of bits used to produce colour in each pixel on a monitor display. The more bits used, the greater the number of colours that can be displayed, provided that a graphics card and monitor have the capability to display them. Common bit ranges are 8-bit colour (256 colours), 16-bit colour (thousands of colours), and 24-bit colour (millions of colours). Most monitors in use today can display at least 16-bit colour.

Colour Temperature: Measured in degrees Kelvin, reference to colour temperature provides a standard for defining standard colours emitted from computer displays. This rating indicates the colour of a CRT or bulb when it is lit. It also indicates the general atmosphere (warm or cool) created by a particular CRT or tube.



Sony SDM-S51
+ Good looks
- Average performance, low refresh rates, minimal feature set



Sharp LL-T1520-B
+ Above average performance
- Heaviest



Sharp LL-T15G3B
+ Outstanding performance
- No built in speakers; minimal feature set